8
Sharpening the Cutting Edge

After a long but successful stay in Nagaland, our battalion moved to Hyderabad for a well-deserved peace tenure. The unit lines were near the Golconda Fort. I had been appointed as the adjutant, which is a key assignment in a unit. Training and sports are the core activities during peace-time soldiering and these kept us busy.

As it happened, I couldn't stay long with the battalion at Hyderabad and was posted to the Intelligence School, Poona in 1970. I stayed there as an instructor for three years. This assignment played an extraordinarily important role in shaping my military career, and in honing my professional skills and enhancing my knowledge base. In those days we did the General Intelligence Course for a duration of three months. It was called the mini-staff course. The most important thing we learnt was how to do an intelligence appreciation, that is, analyse the various options available to the enemy or adversary and deduce his most likely course of action. Our own plans should only be evolved thereafter. Later, as an instructor, this approach to problem-solving became second nature to me.

The biggest weakness in many of us in the defence forces is that we seldom give adequate consideration to the enemy's plans; we tend to make excellent plans in which the enemy's actions are made to 'fit' into our scheme of things. Therefore, such plans are likely to go awry when the enemy adopts a course of action that we have not anticipated. In any case, we need to remember that the best of plans hardly survive the first engagement. There must be inbuilt flexibility to modify, change or adopt Plan B to exploit any unexpected